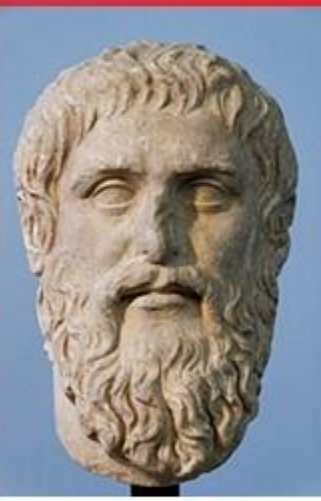
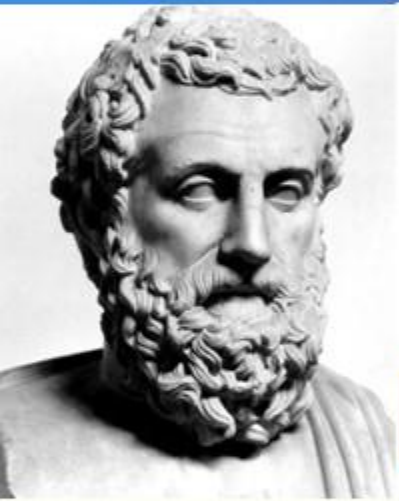


ETHICS, INTEGRITY & APTITUDE



MODULE - 5

**ETHICAL DECISION
MAKING**

ETHICS, INTEGRITY & APTITUDE

CASE OF AN MBA STUDENT



Rohit is studying MBA from a good B School. In his final semester, he interviewed for an opportunity with *Invest Wisely Limited* based in Mumbai. The job profile matched his expertise and attitude and the interviewers were sure that he would be an asset to the company and would help the clients grow.

However, shortly after the interview, the company lost a big contract and announced a hiring freeze.

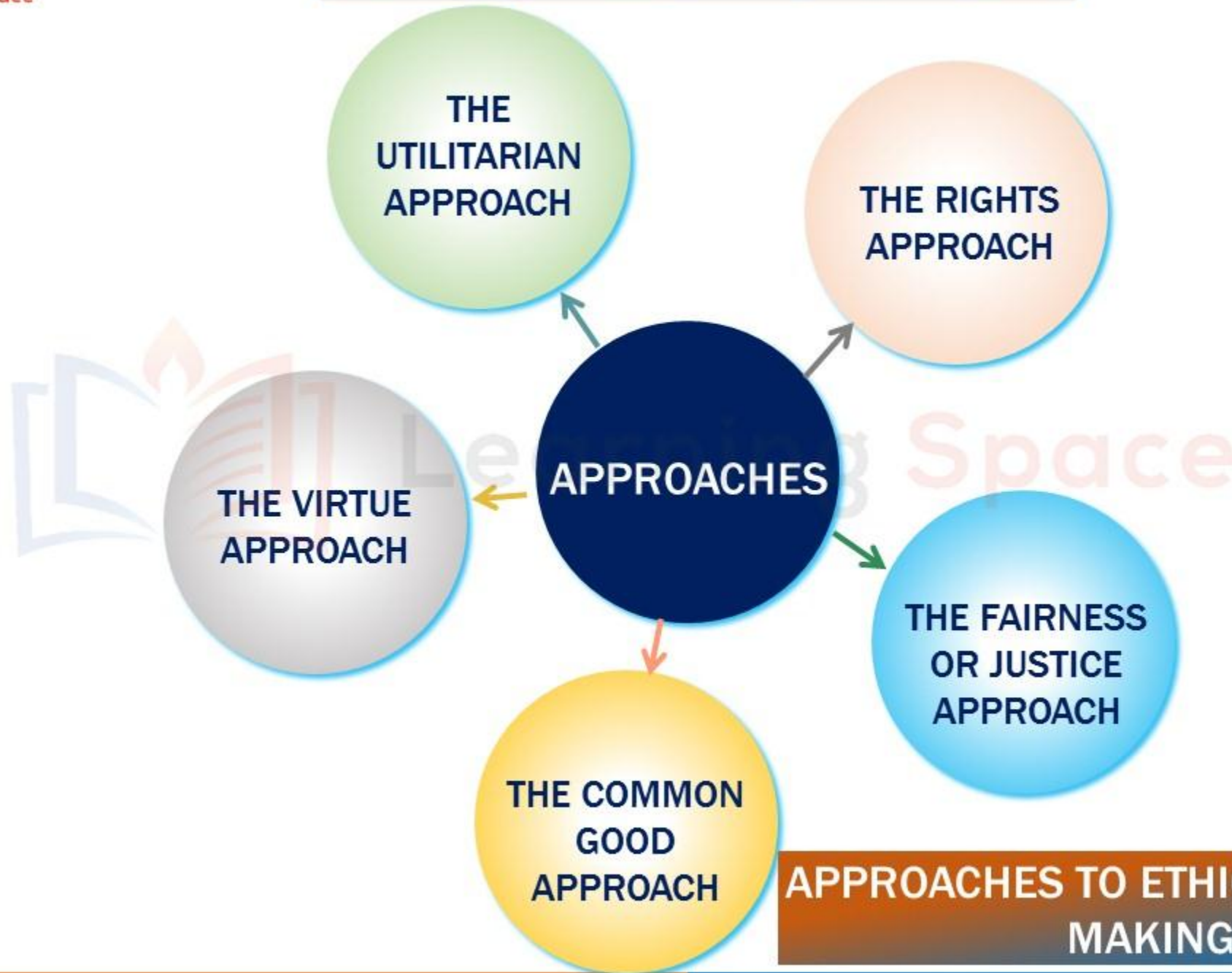
In the meantime, he got two decent offers from the companies with whom he had interviewed previously. After a lot of prodding and pressurising from parents and his friends, he finally accepted an offer with *Let's Win Limited* in Coimbatore.

A week later, he received a call from *Invest Wisely*, saying that the firm is recruiting again.





What course of action would you recommend?



APPROACHES TO ETHICAL DECISION MAKING

1 UTILITARIAN APPROACH



War on terror balances the good achieved in ending terrorism with the harm done through death, injuries and destruction.

This question answers the dilemma of which option will produce the greatest benefits and least harm.

The ethical action is the one that produces the **greatest good** and does the **least harm** for all stakeholders e.g. clients, colleagues, and the community.

The utilitarian approach **deals with consequences**; it tries both to increase the good done and to reduce the harm done.

What benefits and what harms will each course of action produce, and which alternative will lead to the **best overall consequences**?

APPROACHES TO ETHICAL DECISION MAKING

1 UTILITARIAN APPROACH



Instrumentally good



Inherently good

High grades, a good job and a big salary are **instrumentally good**, while pleasure and happiness **are inherently good**.

Jeremy Bentham applied the idea to the criminal justice system of eighteenth-century England. At the time, punishment was based on the ancient idea of **retribution**, meaning paying back.

He believed that **criminal justice should be rooted in reason** rather than an emotional desire to make the criminal suffer.

Some of the classical utilitarians favored the idea that there is **a single ultimate end**, which they called **utility**. Utility can be pleasure, happiness, or whatever someone prefers.

Utility: the usefulness of something, especially in a practical way.



The **Universal Declaration of Human Rights** is an example that embraces and exhibits the values of a Rights Based Ethical System.

2 RIGHTS APPROACH

The ethical action is the one that best **protects and respects the moral rights** of those affected.

It comes from the belief that **humans have a dignity** based on their human nature or on their **ability to choose freely** what they do with their lives.

Humans have **a right to be treated as ends** and not merely puppets where the end justifies the means. It believes that **if the act does not respect everyone's moral rights, it is wrong** to act.



2 RIGHTS APPROACH

However, the **list of moral rights** or choices is now **widely debated**. There is now an argument that non-humans such as animals and fetuses also have rights.

Examples of rights/choices are: what kind of life to lead, to be told the truth, not to be injured, to a degree of privacy.

Also, **rights imply duties** – in particular, the duty to respect others' rights.

What moral rights do the affected parties have, and which course of action best represents those rights?

APPROACHES TO ETHICAL DECISION MAKING

3 FAIRNESS APPROACH

Ethical actions should **treat all human beings equally**, or if unequally, then fairly based on some standard that is defensible.

This approach gives the individual the opportunity to **reflect if the action is fair to the people**.

Example: people getting paid more based on their greater contribution to the organization is generally deemed fair.

Which course of action treats everyone the same, except where there is a morally justifiable reason not to, and does not show favoritism or discrimination?



Protests against high bonuses pocketed by top bank executives



Teachers favour top students, even in examinations



4 COMMON GOOD APPROACH

This approach suggests that the interactions with your community are the basis of ethical reasoning.

Respect and compassion for all others, especially the vulnerable, are requirements of such reasoning.

This approach calls attention to the common conditions that are important to the welfare of everyone.

Common conditions: a system of laws, effective police and fire departments, health care, a public educational system, or even public recreational areas.

4 COMMON GOOD APPROACH

This approach draws **special attention to marginalized groups** such as persons with disabilities, old people.

Which course of action advances the **common good**?

This question helps drive our choice to decide if the action taken will be **good for ourselves and the community**.

It opens the door to **other questions** related to the type of society we want to become and how we achieve that.



Common conditions: a system of laws, effective police department, health care, a public educational system, or public recreational areas.



An employee who displays ethical behavior at work based on the virtues they hold dear are often seen as more reliable and dependable by their superiors.

This question reflects what kind of person you should be and what it will do to your character.

5

VIRTUE APPROACH

Virtues are dispositions and habits that enable us to act according to the highest potential of our character.

Examples of virtues are: honesty, courage, compassion, generosity, tolerance, love, fidelity, integrity, fairness, self-control, and prudence.

Virtue ethics asks of any action, "What kind of person will I become if I do this?" or "Is this action consistent with my acting at my best?"

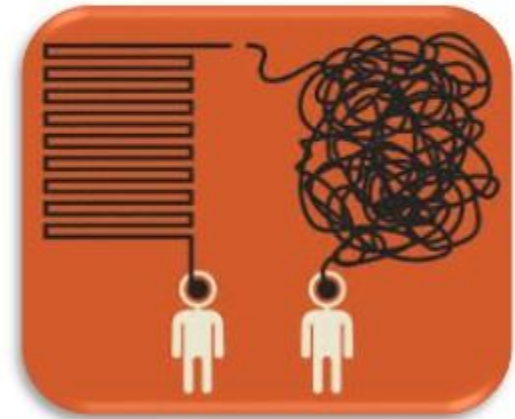
Which course of action develops moral virtues?

Approaches to Ethical Decision Making

THE UTILITARIAN APPROACH	Which option will produce the most good and do the least harm?
THE RIGHTS APPROACH	Which option best respects the rights of all stakeholders?
THE FAIRNESS OR JUSTICE APPROACH	Which option treats people equally or proportionately?
THE COMMON GOOD APPROACH	Which option best serves the community as a whole, not just some members?
THE VIRTUE APPROACH	Which option leads me to act as the sort of person I want to be?

- 1 ■ The **content** of some of the specific **approaches**.

- 3 ■ The same **set** of human rights and civil **rights**.



- 2 ■ The idea of **what** constitutes the **common good**.

- 4 ■ The **distinction** between a **good** and a **harmful** action.



Although each of the approaches helps us determine what standards of behavior can be considered ethical, there are **still problems to be solved**.

The different approaches **may not** all **answer** the question "What is ethical?" **in** the same way.

But, each approach **gives us** important **information** with which to determine what is ethical in a particular circumstance.

And much more often than not, the different approaches may **lead to similar answers**.

*Having **a method** for ethical decision making is, thus, essential.*

ETHICS, INTEGRITY & APTITUDE

CASE OF A SCHOOL TEACHER



You are a teacher in a government school attended by students from underprivileged segments of the society. A student Gargi joined in 1st class this academic year.

After a couple of weeks of observation, you suspect that the girl is afraid to talk to any male members and suggest to her mother that she seek professional help.

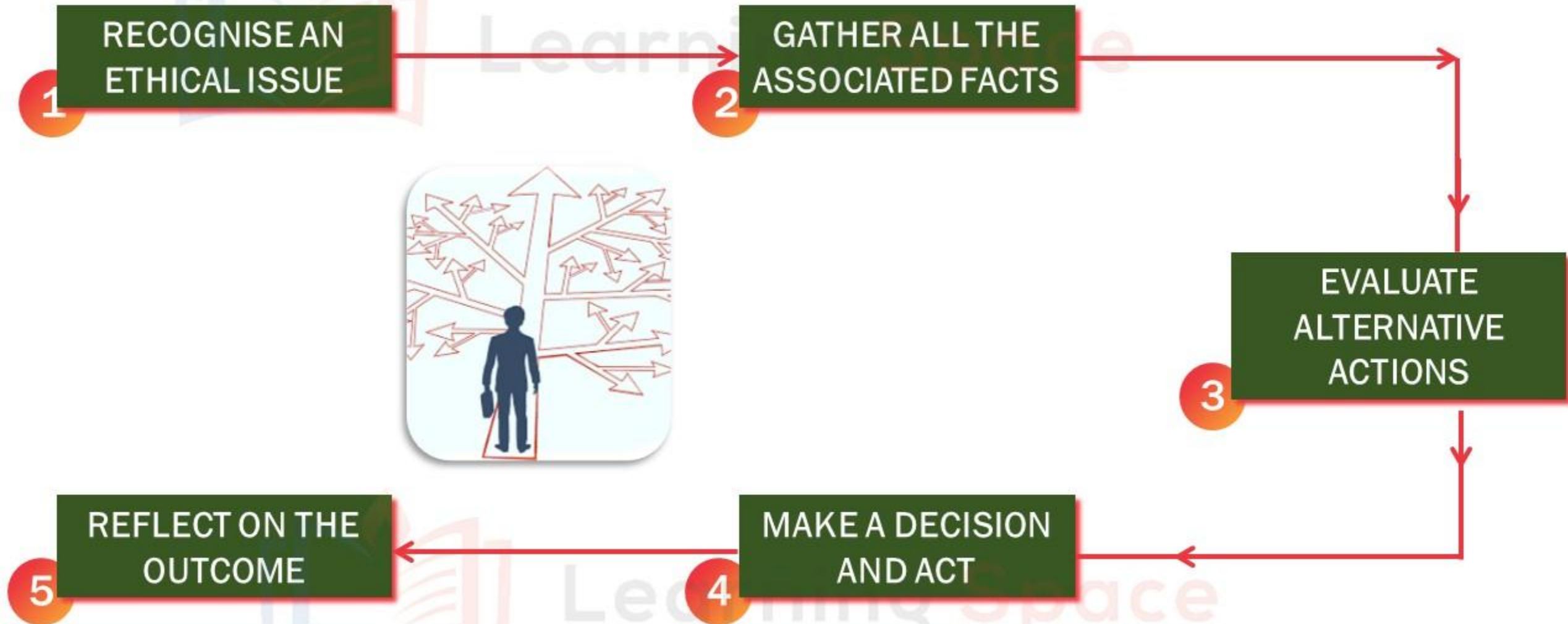


But the mother responded that she is highly uneducated and she can't relay this information to the girl's step-father because of his own chronic health problems.

You strongly suspect that the girl is a victim of sexual abuse.

What would you do?

ETHICAL DECISION MAKING PROCESS



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